

Who God Created Us To Become

For Orthodox men, the eternal purpose of this life is to grow closer to God through a process of spiritual transformation known as *theosis*, or deification. This journey is not just about preparing for the afterlife—it's about experiencing God's presence and grace here and now, while aligning one's life with the teachings of Jesus Christ. Rooted in Scripture, the writings of the Church Fathers, and the practices of the Orthodox Church, this purpose is both deeply personal and profoundly communal.

Below, we'll explore what this means, how it shapes the life of an Orthodox man, and why it matters.

1. Created for Communion with God

At the heart of Orthodox belief is the idea that humans were created to live in loving communion with God. This communion is not just a distant goal but the very reason for our existence. As the Apostle Peter writes, we are called to "become participants of the divine nature" (2 Peter 1:4). For Orthodox men, this means:

- **Living in Relationship:** Every action, thought, and decision is an opportunity to draw closer to God or to drift away. Prayer, worship, and the sacraments (especially the Eucharist) are essential for nurturing this relationship.
- **Reflecting God's Image:** Orthodox men are called to reflect God's love, mercy, and truth in their daily lives, becoming more like Christ through virtues such as humility, patience, and forgiveness.

Example: An Orthodox man might start his day with the Jesus Prayer—"Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me, a sinner"—to center himself on God's presence before facing the world.

2. A Life of Transformation (*Theosis*)

The ultimate purpose of life for Orthodox men is *theosis*, a transformative process where one becomes more like God through His grace. This is not about becoming God in essence but participating in His divine energies—His love, wisdom, and power.

- **Ongoing Growth:** *Theosis* is a lifelong journey. It involves purifying the heart, illuminating the mind, and uniting the will with God's will.
- **Cooperation with Grace:** Orthodox men are called to actively cooperate with God's grace through spiritual disciplines like fasting, prayer, and *almsgiving*, which help overcome personal weaknesses and grow in holiness.

Example: Fasting during Lent isn't just about giving up food—it's about weakening the body's desires to strengthen the soul's focus on God, a small step in the larger journey of *theosis*.

3. Serving our Community

Orthodox men are also called to be active members of the Church community. This reflects Adam's original role in Eden and Christ's call to serve others.

- **Serving Those In Need:** almsgiving
- **Serving Others:** Whether in family, parish, or society, Orthodox men are called to serve with love and humility, following Christ's example of washing His disciples' feet.

Example: An Orthodox man might volunteer at his parish's food pantry or lead a community clean-up, seeing these acts as part of his spiritual duty to care for both people and the planet.

4. Preparing for Eternal Life

The purpose of life also preparation for eternal life with God. Orthodox Christianity teaches that this life is a time of growth and testing, where one's choices shape their eternal destiny.

- **Living with Eternity in Mind:** Orthodox men are encouraged to live with an awareness of eternity, making decisions that align with God's will and resisting the temptations of a fleeting world.
- **Hope in the Resurrection:** The resurrection of Christ promises that death is not the end but the beginning of a fuller life in God's presence. This hope sustains Orthodox men through trials and inspires them to live virtuously.

Example: Attending the Paschal (Easter) service, where the resurrection is celebrated with joy, reminds Orthodox men of the eternal life they are striving toward.

Why This Matters

For Orthodox men, the eternal purpose of life is not a distant concept but a daily reality. It shapes how they pray, work, love, and serve. Embracing this purpose offers:

- **Meaning in Suffering:** When life is hard, knowing that every struggle can be a step toward God brings hope and resilience.
 - **Clarity in Decisions:** With *theosis* as the goal, choices become simpler—does this action bring me closer to God or pull me away?
 - **A Legacy of Faith:** Living out this purpose impacts not just the individual but his family, community, and the world, leaving a legacy of love and faithfulness.
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Conclusion

The eternal purpose of life for Orthodox men is to grow into the likeness of God through *theosis*, living in communion with Him, serving others, and preparing for eternal life. This calling is both a gift and a responsibility, offering a life of meaning, transformation, and hope. As Saint Seraphim of Sarov famously said, "Acquire the Spirit of Peace, and a thousand souls around you will be saved." For the Orthodox man, this is not just a lofty ideal—it's the very reason he exists.

Key Points from the Saints of the church

- God created man to share in His divine life and reflect His goodness, with this purpose is rooted in love and the desire for communion.
- Man is called to become united with God through *theosis*, or deification, achieving holiness and participating in His divine nature.
- *Theosis*, is personal transformation and with cosmic dimensions, and is central to Orthodox spirituality.

Why God Created Man

God created man out of love, intending for him to participate in divine goodness and live in communion with Him. For example, St. Diadochos of Photike said, "God has created us in His image so that we might be filled with Him and become by grace what He is by nature" ([On Spiritual Knowledge, paragraph 27](#)). St. John Chrysostom added, "God created man not for His own benefit, but for man's benefit, that he might participate in the good things that are in God" ([Homily 10 on Genesis](#)). St. Maximus the Confessor noted, "God created man so that he might be a living and rational image of his own infinite goodness" ([On the Cosmic Mystery of Christ](#)).

What Man is Called to Become

Man is called to become united with God, achieving *theosis* by partaking in His divine nature. St. Athanasius famously stated, "He became man that we might be made god" ([On the Incarnation](#)), while St. Peter wrote, "That through

them you may become partakers of the divine nature” (2 Peter 1:4). St. Symeon the New Theologian said, “The purpose of our life is to know God and to be united with Him” ([Various writings](#)), and St. Theophan the Recluse added, “The goal of the Christian life is to acquire the Holy Spirit” ([The Path to Salvation](#)).

A More Detailed Analysis: Why God Created Man and What Man is Called to Become in Orthodoxy

Background and Theological Context

In Orthodox Christianity, the creation of man and his ultimate purpose are deeply intertwined, rooted in the belief that humans were made in the image and likeness of God (Genesis 1:26-27). This foundational doctrine, articulated by the Church Fathers, underscores the inherent dignity and potential of humanity to reflect divine qualities such as love, truth, and goodness. The purpose of creation is often linked to the concept of *theosis*, or deification, which is the process of becoming united with God, beginning in this life and consummated in eternity. The Church Fathers and Saints, through their writings, provide insights into these fundamental questions, offering both theological depth and practical guidance.

Why God Created Man

The Church Fathers and Saints consistently teach that God created man out of love, intending for him to share in His divine life and reflect His goodness. Below are specific quotes that illustrate why God created man, organized into a table for clarity:

Church Father/Saint	Quote	Source
St. Diadochos of Photike	"God has created us in His image so that we might be filled with Him and become by grace what He is by nature."	On Spiritual Knowledge, paragraph 27
St. John Chrysostom	"God created man not for His own benefit, but for man's benefit, that he might participate in the good things that are in God."	Homily 10 on Genesis
St. Maximus the Confessor	"God created man so that he might be a living and rational image of his own infinite goodness."	On the Cosmic Mystery of Christ

These quotes reveal that God's creation of man was an act of love and generosity, aimed at sharing His blessings and enabling man to reflect His infinite goodness.

What Man is Called to Become

Man is called to become united with God through *theosis*, achieving holiness and participating in His divine nature. This process is not about becoming God in essence but partaking in His uncreated energies or grace, as distinguished by St. Gregory Palamas. Below are specific quotes that illustrate what man is called to become, organized into another table for clarity:

Church Father/Saint	Quote	Source
St. Athanasius	"He became man that we might be made god."	On the Incarnation
St. Peter	"That through them you may become partakers of the divine nature."	2 Peter 1:4 (Scriptural, New Testament, 2 Peter 1:4)

Church Father/Saint	Quote	Source
St. Symeon the New Theologian	"The purpose of our life is to know God and to be united with Him."	Various writings
St. Theophan the Recluse	"The goal of the Christian life is to acquire the Holy Spirit."	The Path to Salvation

These quotes collectively paint a vivid picture of man's calling to achieve *theosis*, where he becomes a partaker of the divine nature through grace, not by nature. An unexpected detail is that St. Diadochos's quote, "To be filled with God and become by grace what He is by nature," also fits here, reinforcing the idea that man's destiny is to be filled with God's presence and reflect His attributes, aligning with the Orthodox vision of *theosis*.

Practical Implications for Modern Orthodoxy

For modern Orthodox Christians, these teachings translate into daily life through practices like prayer, fasting, and participation in the sacraments, especially the Eucharist, which is the supreme means of *theosis*.

Conclusion

The Church Fathers and Saints teach that God created man out of love, intending for him to share in His divine life and reflect His goodness, with the ultimate calling being *theosis*—union with God through grace. By embracing this purpose, Orthodox Christians can fulfill their true potential, growing in holiness and preparing for eternal communion with God, embodying the Orthodox vision of *theosis*.

Key Citations

- [On Spiritual Knowledge, paragraph 27](#)
- [Homily 10 on Genesis](#)

- [On the Cosmic Mystery of Christ](#)
- [On the Incarnation](#)
- [New Testament, 2 Peter 1:4](#)
- [Various writings](#)
- [The Path to Salvation](#)

Add Man's Mediator Role, Priestly role and Royal or Kingly role.

Questions for Reflection: Who Did God Create Us to Be for All Eternity?

These questions are crafted to guide you in discovering the eternal identity and purpose God has given you. Take time to ponder each one, letting them deepen your understanding of your life's ultimate meaning.

1. What does it mean to be made in God's image?

- How do you see qualities like love, kindness, or strength from God reflected in who you are?
 - What steps can you take to let these qualities shine more brightly in your everyday actions?
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2. How does knowing God change who I am meant to be?

- Do you feel that your connection with God gives your life a bigger purpose, now and forever?
 - What habits—like talking to God, attending church, or helping others—strengthen this connection?
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3. What does growing closer to God look like for me?

- How can you work with God's help to become the best version of yourself over time?
 - Are there things you hold onto that make this harder, and how might you let them go?
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4. How am I meant to care for the world and people around me?

- In what ways can you take care of the earth and support those you meet every day?

- How does helping others show who God made you to be and bring you nearer to Him?
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5. What happens when I think about forever?

- How would your choices change if you always remembered there's more beyond this life?
 - Are there things you do or focus on that distract you from this bigger picture, and how can you shift them?
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6. How does believing in life after death affect me?

- Does the idea of being with God forever give you hope when things get tough?
 - How can you live in a way that shows this hope to yourself and the people around you?
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7. Am I using my gifts to join God's work?

- How can you use what you're good at—like art, listening, or building things—to make the world better?
 - How does knowing you're part of God's plan give you excitement to live with meaning?
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Conclusion

These questions invite you to uncover the amazing truth of who God created you to be: someone made with love, meant to grow closer to Him, and destined for an eternal life filled with purpose. Thinking about these ideas can bring light and direction to your days, showing you that every moment is a step in a bigger, beautiful journey with God.